the two remained less than cordial. It's only now after being out of power since 2017 that the two have reconciled. Akhilesh made Azam SP general secretary at the party's national working committee meeting on January 29.

In 2019, even as the whole state fell to a saffron wave, Azam won the Rampur Lok Sabha seat as an SP candidate. Even then, he couldn't stay away from controversy, making allegedly unsavoury remarks against the BJP candidate and former Rampur MP, actress-turned-neta Jayaprada. She complained to the Election Commission, and that case too is pending with the MP-MLA court. Azam soon resigned from his Rampur MLA assembly seat which his wife Tanjim Fatima later won in a byelection. Younger son Abdullah Azam was elected from the Swar assembly seat in both 2017 and 2022, but had to let go of it both times after the court convicted him in various cases.

The 2022 byelections necessitated by Azam forfeiting his seats saw the BJP winning both the Rampur LS seat as well as the assembly seat that goes by that name. The SP blames the defeats on the Yogi regime's "revenge politics" and points to the 100-plus cases filed against Azam. Farhan Khan, his lawyer and spokesperson, says, "Moradabad commissioner and former Rampur district magistrate (DM) Aunjaneya Kumar Singh has filed fake cases against Azam at the behest of the Yogi government. In the byelections too, the local police did not allow Muslim voters to leave their homes on polling day, which was why the SP candidate lost."

Azam first tangled with Aunjaneya Singh during the 2019 Lok Sabha election campaign where he reportedly abused the DM at a rally. For his troubles, a case of hate speech was registered against Azam. After the results, the IAS officer created half a dozen administrative teams to investigate the properties of the Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust Azam headed in Rampur. This led to charges of land grabbing and intimidation involving Azam's two-decade-old dream project, the 'Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar University' (see *On Disputed Land*). The same year, the district administration also had Azam's name included in the state government's land mafia portal. Rampur SP district president Virendra Goyal says, "More than 90 per cent of the cases filed against Azam were registered after the 2019 LS election. It is clear that the administration was working on the instructions of the Yogi government." In March 2021, the Yogi government appointed Aunjaneya commissioner of Moradabad extending his deputation in the state. The IAS officer, though, denies that the cases are politically motivated. "All the cases against Azam Khan are based on documentary evidence. It is wrong to accuse me of discrimination," he says.

The 74-year-old leader and his family have been the pivot of UP's Muslim politics for long but now spend most of their time in and out of courtrooms on various cases. His pet project, the Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar University, faces over a hundred cases and is at serious risk of being derecognised. Indeed, it now looks like Azam's hold over Rampur itself might be weak-

ON DISPUTED LAND

Yogi's government has been after Azam and his family, alleging their involvement in a number of land grab cases in Rampur

The Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar University is named after the great early-20th-century educationist who made Rampur a major centre of education. Unfortunately, now the varsity is more known for the property disputes surrounding its chancellor Azam Khan. Spread over 350 acres, it was established in 2006 during the Mulayam Singh regime in UP. The university administration claims some 5,000 students study here for 33 courses, including engineering and mass communication. Azam had runins with many of UP's governors before managing to get the varsity minority status in 2014. Since its inception, the university has been facing allegations of illegal encroachment. Bande Ali, 45, from Singankheda village that abuts the university on the north side, has been fighting for years to get back his two bighas of land. Ali says, "In 2014, a boundary wall came up, which included my land within the varsity grounds. My name is mentioned in all the documents...." Ali had almost given up hope till, in March 2019, he submitted a complaint to then Rampur DM Aunjaneya Kumar Singh. Investigations found that the university had illegally occupied the land of many farmers. On July 12, 2019, the first case was filed against Azam. Ali says, "The farmers did not trust the administration, so they filed cases on their own too." In just a month, more than 20 cases were filed against Azam and his associates. The number of cases has since crossed 100.

"RAMPUR'S LOCALS HAVE FILED CASES AGAINST AZAM KHAN. THE YOGI GOVERNMENT IS ENSURING JUSTICE TO THE VICTIMS OF HIS TERROR"

–BRAJESH PATHAK, *Uttar Pradesh deputy CM*